The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

America's secretary of state received a standing ovation at the Munich Security Conference. **Marco Rubio** said "the United States and Europe belong together", emphasising the Western allies' common civilisational bonds (while criticising Europe's deindustrialisation and mass migration). His message is being widely seen as an attempt to mend the damage done to the relationship at last year's conference by the speech of America's vice-president J.D. Vance.

The president of the European Commission, **Ursula von der Leyen**, said she was reassured by Mr Rubio's words, but noted that "some lines have been crossed that cannot be uncrossed". She also stated that "Europe has no other choice but to become independent". Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, admitted that America's security umbrella had allowed Europe to develop bad habits, but added "we must break them".

Five European countries, including Britain, said it was "highly likely" that a poison developed from the Ecuador dart frog killed **Alexei Navalny,** a Russian opposition leader. They blamed The Kremlin for his death, two years ago, in a Siberian penal colony.

The announcement came as British foreign secretary Yvette Cooper met Navalny's widow at the Munich Security Conference.

America's armed forces said they had carried out a series of strikes against **Islamic State** targets in **Syria** over the past two weeks. The strikes were in retaliation for an ambush in December that killed two American soldiers and an American civilian interpreter. US Central Command said at least 50 members of IS have been killed or captured since the ambush.

Gunmen reportedly killed at least 30 people in raids on several communities in northern **Nigeria**, where such armed groups are known as bandits. Nigeria has long faced several interlocking security crises; both bandits and jihadists menace the country's north-west, and they are increasingly threatening the central regions. Earlier this month jihadists killed around 170 people in the mid-western Kwara state.

Casey Wasserman, an American talent agent, said he was selling his firm after his ties to **Jeffrey Epstein**, a dead sex offender, emerged in emails released by the Justice Department. Chappell Roan, a singer, and other clients have left the agency in recent days. He insisted he "never had a personal or business relationship" with Epstein. He will keep his role as organiser of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Organisers indefinitely postponed **Cuba's** annual **cigar festival**, which was scheduled for the end of February, blaming America's fuel blockade. In January the Trump administration placed an effective embargo on foreign-oil shipments to the island, which has suffered power cuts and instituted a shortened work week. In 2025 the festival's cigar auction yielded more than $18m, which apparently supports Cuba's health-care system.

Word of the week: Alpha, the name of a Christian starter course that has become one of Britain's most successful cultural exports.

Read the full story.

Photograph: AP

America’s immigration crackdown after Minnesota

This week the Trump administration announced the winding down of its huge immigration-enforcement operation in Minnesota’s Twin Cities, which began in December. Tom Homan, Donald Trump’s “border czar”, said it had yielded “successful results”. More than 4,000 people were arrested. But the operation sparked widespread protests, which intensified after Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents killed two American citizens in Minneapolis.

The announcement looked like a tactical retreat. Mr Homan, admitting that not everything had been “conducted perfectly”, claimed that jails were now co-operating with ICE—something that many counties already did. He could not answer how many were newly co-operating. The unpopular crackdown has given Democrats leverage to demand constraints on ICE as lawmakers negotiate a funding bill for the Department of Homeland Security. But they have thus far failed to reach a deal. In any case, the agency has plenty of cash from other sources. Another Democratic city could soon be subject to the ICE treatment.

Photograph: AP

Fears of a new war in the Horn of Africa

Over the past week Ethiopia's army has been moving large numbers of troops and heavy weapons towards the northern region of Tigray, prompting fears that it may be about to launch a big military offensive. The movements followed clashes between the Ethiopian army and forces loyal to the Tigray People's Liberation Front, Tigray's ruling party. The two sides fought a devastating war from 2020 to 2022. The chances of further fighting in Tigray are rising.

More worrying is the risk that conflict could spread to Eritrea. Ethiopia's government believes the TPLF and allied rebel groups are receiving arms from the country, which borders Tigray. On February 7th Ethiopia publicly accused Eritrea of "outright aggression". Eritrea's government responded that Ethiopia had waged "hostile campaigns against Eritrea for more than two years". The United Nations' human-rights chief has urged both parties to lower the temperature. But full-blown war is not out of the question.

Photograph: Reuters

Indian football’s own goal

The Indian Super League launched more than a decade ago, amid much fanfare, in an attempt to boost football’s development in cricket-mad India. Reliance, the country’s biggest conglomerate, provided money as a commercial partner; Bollywood stars invested in teams and brought the glamour.

But the glitz has long since given way to the gritty realities of football administration. The league’s latest season was due to start in September, but has been on hiatus after the collapse of a commercial-rights agreement between the All India Football Federation, the sport’s governing body, and Football Sports Development Limited, a division of Reliance.

After months of uncertainty the new season finally begins on Saturday, though without a commercial partner. The delays have been costly for teams, which have had to sack staff and cut players’ wages. For Indian football, it seems, the own goals are mostly scored off the pitch.

Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Tarique Rahman, Bangladesh's familiar new prime minister

When Tarique Rahman flew into Dhaka in December, it was the first time he had set foot in Bangladesh for 17 years. Soon he will be prime minister. His Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) secured a landslide victory at a general election on Thursday—the first poll since Gen-Z protesters toppled Bangladesh's despotic former ruler, Sheikh Hasina Wajed, 18 months ago.

Mr Rahman hails from political royalty. The BNP was founded by his father, Ziaur Rahman, a military hero who ran Bangladesh from 1977 to 1981, when he was assassinated. His mother, Khaleda Zia, served as prime minister for two terms in the 1990s and 2000s. During those decades the BNP alternated in power with Sheikh Hasina's Awami League. Alas, neither ruled with distinction. Corruption flourished. And the women who ran Bangladesh's two biggest parties indulged in a bitter personal feud.

Mr Rahman did not formally serve in his mother's administrations. But many Bangladeshis saw him as a power in them—albeit not a positive one. Leaked American diplomatic cables (written in 2008 and 2009) alleged that by the mid-2000s he "was widely considered one of the most corrupt individuals in Bangladesh", and that he was "notorious for flagrantly and frequently demanding bribes". (He has always denied wrongdoing).

In 2007 Mr Rahman was detained by the army, which had briefly taken power in an effort to reset the country's bitter politics and for a time was locking up politicians of all stripes. Upon his release in 2008 he moved to Britain, ostensibly to receive treatment for spinal injuries suffered in military custody. But his sojourn turned into permanent self-exile after voters returned Sheikh Hasina to office. Her government convicted Mr Rahman in absentia of numerous offences and sentenced him to life in jail.

But Bangladesh's revolution in 2024 finally provided him with a way back. Newly independent courts quashed his convictions, permitting his return. His mother died a few days after he landed; an upswell of sympathy gave his political campaign a boost. Meanwhile, student revolutionaries struggled to build from scratch a party that Bangladeshis would trust to run the country. Many people worried that the BNP's main rival—an Islamist outfit—was untested in office and not as religiously moderate as it claimed.

How will Mr Rahman govern? These days Mr Rahman, 60, is softly spoken and bespectacled. His supporters, who include many of Bangladesh's businesspeople and its liberal elite, say he is a different man to the one who left. And political opponents have long had incentive to blacken his character, they point out.

He is certainly saying the right things. Interviewed by *The Economist* on the campaign trail, he said his government would ensure free speech, maintain order and bear down on graft. Traditionally his party is of the centre-right. He promises to help investors create jobs. He pledges to build new canals to solve water shortages and to plant 50m trees a year. And he insists he will not use the powers of the state to go after political rivals—a scourge that has plagued Bangladesh for decades. "Being vengeful does not do anyone any good," he says.

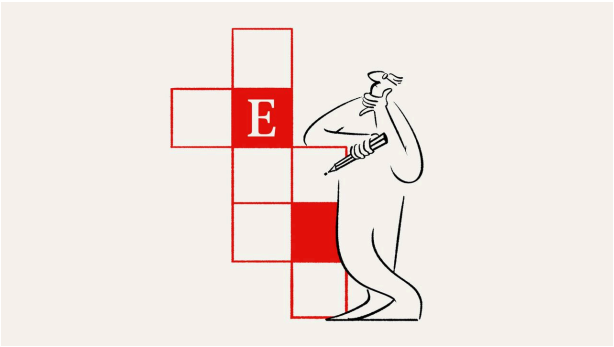

Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Military garb sounds like it will get your motor running (5)

2 across - Propose a flat surface (5)

3 across - An Aussie pickup with some road ahead knows where to go (5)

1 down - I'm a streaker, weirdly, for Britain's first among equals (4,7)

Straight clues

1 across - The army's favourite shade (5)

2 across - An elementary display of facts or figures (5)

3 across - The right direction (5)

1 down - SW1A's most powerful knight, for now (4,7)

.Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Guillaume Laroch, Calgary, Canada
Maria Manuela DaCosta, Eau Claire, Wisconsin, America
Sverre Prytz, Zurich, Switzerland

They gave the right answers of The Ugly Duckling, Alcatraz, Wales, Prince Harry and Madison Square Garden. The theme is Clint Eastwood films: "The Good, the Bad and the Ugly", "Escape from Alcatraz", "The Outlaw Josey Wales", "Dirty Harry" and "The Bridges of Madison County".

The questions were:

Monday: In which Hans Christian Andersen tale does the main character turn out to be a swan?
Tuesday: Which American prison was home to both Al Capone and Machine Gun Kelly?
Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of Britain?
Thursday: Who is currently fifth in line to the British throne?
Friday: Which Manhattan venue is home to the New York Knicks?

Power concedes nothing without a demand. It never did, and it never will.

Frederick Douglass